Nitish made the results of his state survey public, the Congress leader reiterated: "The greater the population, the greater the rights. This is our pledge."

Traditionally, though, the Congress had not been in favour of caste enumeration. Jawaharlal Nehru opposed the idea in 1951. Indira Gandhi put the report of the Mandal Commission—ordered by the Janata Party government that came to power in 1977—on the back burner even though it was submitted in 1980. Even Rajiv Gandhi ignored it. When V.P. Singh implemented OBC reservation, Rajiv termed it as an attempt to divide the country along caste lines. But the party had begun waking up to the OBC potential during the United Progressive Alliance regime. In 2006, the Manmohan Singh government announced 27 per cent reservation for OBCs in admission to central educational institutions. In 2011, the government conducted a nationwide Socio Economic and Caste Census (SECC) to identify the beneficiaries of the various government schemes. Its findings were not published, though. With the clamour for a caste census growing now, the Congress has thrown its weight behind it, as it feels the issue could be the glue that may bind regional satraps to it and eventually defeat the BJP.

With the BJP reluctant about a caste-based census for fear of disturbing the status quo and upsetting the savarna castes on the eve of several state elections and the general election, the Opposition has been steadily raising the pitch on a nationwide caste census. Most Opposition parties, including the Congress, SP, BSP, RJD, JD(U), Jharkhand Mukti Morcha, Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, Bharat Rashtra Samithi, Telugu Desam Party, the Uddhav Thackeray faction of the Shiv Sena and the Sharad Pawar faction of the Nationalist Congress Party, have been demanding a commitment from the Union government to include caste enumeration whenever the exercise is held next. Some of the non-aligned parties such as the Yuvajana Sramik Rythu Congress Party in Andhra Pradesh and the Biju Janata Dal in Odisha as well as a few of the BJP's allies such as the Ajit Pawar faction of the NCP, the Nishad Party and the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) have joined the chorus.

Meanwhile, several non-BJP-ruled states have, in the past year, either conducted caste surveys or expressed their intent to do so. While Odisha has initiated a caste survey, Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah has decided to accept the results of the 'Socio-Economic and Education Survey' that was conducted in 2015 during his previous stint in power and is likely to release the results next month. In UP, the SP had, in its election manifesto for the 2022 assembly polls, promised to conduct a caste census if voted to power.

Only one Opposition party, the Trinamool Congress, is reportedly unhappy with the idea. West Bengal chief minister and TMC chief Mamata Banerjee's discomfort stems from the alleged advantage that Muslim OBC groups enjoy in the reservation benefits. The West Bengal BJP alleges that the community has cornered 91.5 per cent of the reservation in the state, and Hindu OBC communities have been discriminated against. A caste census may expose her bias, claim Mamata's detractors.

PAST CASTE ENUMERATION

THE DIFFERENT ATTEMPTS TO TABULATE CASTE IN THE COUNTRY. WHILE THE CONSTITUTION MANDATES COUNTING SCs AND STs IN THE CENSUS, IT DOESN'T REQUIRE THE ENUMERATION OF OTHER CASTES

- The last time the OBC population was tabulated was nearly a century ago, in **1931**, when their share was estimated to be 52 per cent of the country's total population
- In **1980**, Mandal Commission submitted a report recommending 27 per cent reservation in government jobs, based on the 1931 estimate of caste census. In 1990, the V.P. Singh government implemented these recommendations
- In **2011**, the government conducted a nationwide Socio Economic and Caste Census (SECC) to identify beneficiaries for various government programmes. The findings of this census were not published though
- Samagra Kutumba Survey/ Intensive Household survey was done in Telangana in **2014** and Praja Sadhikara Survey/

THE BJP HOPES TO BLUNT THE OPPOSITION'S LATEST ATTACK BY TOM-TOMMING ITS SEVERAL WELFARE MEASURES FOR OBCs, INCLUDING THE RECENT VISHWAKARMA SCHEME